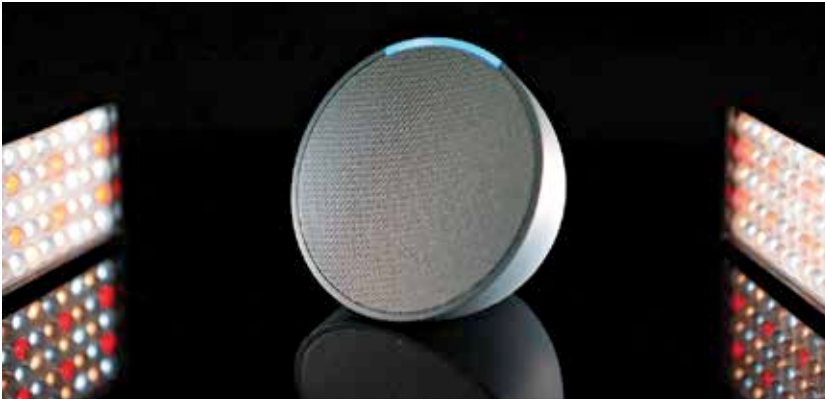




Amazon Echo Pop

How is this tiny smart speaker priced at ₹4,999?

A mazon has added yet another device to their Echo smart speaker line-up – Amazon Echo Pop. On first look, this device looks like an Echo Dot sliced in half. The mesh-covered front with a small arc lighting lining up on the top bezel of the device gives the Echo Pop a distinctive look while still retaining its essence of being an Echo Device. The build quality and materials used here seem to be solid. There's a

nice heft to the device as well, which, when coupled with its rubber feet. Even when you are playing tracks at the highest volume, there will be no rattling. The cable feels secure, and the branding, which there's very little of, is concealed at the bottom of the speaker.

There are not many features, but they work well. Starting off with voice control for smart devices. The time taken by the speaker between getting the command and triggering the action on the nodal device was not that much. During my initial days with the device, I stuck to familiar tracks, and I loved the clarity of vocals that this speaker has. In

tracks like Rescue Me by OneRepublic, which is also a part of our audio testing suite of tracks, the speaker performed exceptionally well. The loudness was also adequate to fill a small room, which is, I assume, a device of this size would be placed in.

One thing that I found missing on both the Echo Dot (5th Gen, 2023 release) and the Echo Pop, was the bass response, despite Amazon heavily advertising it. There's an equaliser baked into the app, which can be used to add some amount of bass boost to the audio. But, out of the box, the device lacks the thumpy bass. This might be a bummer for folks who are into EDM, pop, and other such genres of music which tend to have an emphasis on the bass.

As for the microphone and responsiveness of the device, I have spoken about that in the last section, and it is essentially the best you can get.

The Amazon Echo Pop makes for a great device. However, if you are planning to take the plunge right away, you might want to consider the Echo Dot (5th Gen) as well. In my opinion, it makes for a better value-for-money purchase for the ₹500 extra that you are paying for it.

–Satvik Pandey



Beyblade Burst QuadDrive

Breaks all the expectations in a good way

T he latest addition to Hasbro's Beyblade lineup in India, is the Beyblade Burst QuadDrive. Coming from a generation who's favourite pastime was to have Beyblade battles with their friends, every evening, it was nice to see a brand still trying to make them better than ever. But, when I opened up the package, the feeling that boomers get on the zoomer Reddit threads, hit me. Once it was put together, the fun began. We had gotten two sets of the toy delivered to us which made things even more fun. We tried all the variations of the tip and metal ring combinations that we could. I know people at Hasbro had two in mind - Core+ and Apex+ mode, but our resident engineer, Mithun, got creative with putting together his own little contraption. And, while you are at it, don't forget the Beyblade Burst QuadDrive Beystadium.

–Satvik Pandey